

Student Design Competitions as an awareness-building activity for HCI in the Global South

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ABSTRACT

Increasing the awareness for the field of Human-Computer Interaction (HCI) in the Global South faces many challenges. The value of integrating HCI into computer science programs is still in its infancy across locations. Drawing from 16 years of experiences supporting Student Design Competitions (SDCs) in Latin America and Africa, in this paper we reflect on the intrinsic and extrinsic value of the CHI SDC in conjunction with local and regional events to address this challenge. Via the competitions, students get exposed to global perspectives on HCI, and industry experiences first hand the power of bringing students together. The SDC provides regional and global visibility for local research and HCI groups, which would be impossible otherwise. It allows the student teams to be on par with other teams worldwide. This, in turn, supports local researchers to raise resources both locally and regionally. Participation in the SDC, however, needs reframing and more support to deliver its full potential.

CCS CONCEPTS

• Human-centered computing → Empirical studies in HCI.

KEYWORDS

Student Design Competition, Global South, CHI, HCI education

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1 INTRODUCTION

In the Global South, the introduction of Human-Computer Interaction (HCI) as a scientific discipline into higher education has faced a number of significant hurdles [1, 3, 5, 6, 8, 13]. Historical developments in the field of Computer Science often marginalize HCI, impeding its recognition and integration as a vital and distinct area of study [1, 2, 4, 10]. These structural barriers hamper the dissemination of HCI's inherent value in creating sustainable and user-centered technology.

While professional associations like the Association for Computing Machinery (ACM) and the German Informatics Society advocate for HCI's integration into computer science curricula, the Global South faces major obstacles to get similar institutional and societal support. The lack of HCI courses and educational programs lead to a scarcity of trained HCI professionals in the local industry. This limits the adoption of HCI practices. There is limited financial support to pursue HCI research and/or present it in global venues. In addition, the use of English as the global, de-facto language for knowledge-production and collaboration, and time zone differences with experienced researchers and practitioners from the Global North prevent collaborations [10].

In navigating these complex landscapes, we propose a reframing of strategies to promote HCI as a discipline, one that is conscious of the Global South's distinctive circumstances, emphasizing the indispensability of HCI, empowering its researchers, enhancing its visibility, and rallying the support of influential local stakeholders are all integral to this process. A key catalyst in this transformative journey has been the CHI Student Design Competition (SDC).

Over the past 16 years, the SIGCHI Student Design Competition has served as a vehicle for promoting HCI and driving its growth

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in some locations of the Global South. Drawing more than 300 students globally each year, it offers students a compelling, high-stakes platform to engage with and apply HCI concepts, sparking their curiosity and stimulating innovation. The competition's reach extends far beyond the individual participants, reverberating through academic institutions, the HCI research community, and the broader technology industry. As such, it serves as a talent incubator, nurturing a cohort of future HCI advocates; in engaging students, educators, and the wider community the SDC elevates the profile of HCI and galvanizes local and regional support around its relevance and potential.

Although the SDC has shown value, the presence of students from the Global South in the semi-finals—which take place at the conference site—is still very low. More than 70% of the teams that reached the semi-finals since its start in 2004 are from the US (58%), the UK (7%) and Canada (6%). The semi-finals are largely dominated by just a few institutions. Out of 145 teams that reached the semi-finals, 35 were based at the University of Michigan, 30 at the University of Indiana, 17 at Carnegie Mellon University and 17 at the University College London. Following the analysis of Linxen et.al. [7], the competition is dominated by teams from Western, educated, industrialized, rich and democratic (WEIRD) institutions. To raise awareness about how the SDC could further support the field of HCI in the Global South, it becomes critical to understand the experiences, opportunities, and challenges of those few who have already made efforts to participate.

In this paper, we address this need by presenting the experiences of professors and students conducting initiatives in *four* countries in the Global South (Mexico, South Africa, Ecuador, and Argentina) who have put together initiatives for motivating students' participation in the CHI SDC. Their perspectives range from 16 to one year of experience organizing SDC trainings and competitions in the Global South. Specifically, we explore the intrinsic and extrinsic value of the SDC from their perspective. We look at their added value as well as the challenges of setting up these events in the Global South. We consider the SDC's impact on diverse stakeholders—students, academic institutions, individual researchers, industry partners, and the CHI conference—and explore the opportunities it engenders as well as the obstacles it confronts. We focus on the impact as well as the process to prepare and train the students for the competition.

2 METHODOLOGY

The case studies include two geographical regions, with a total of four countries, each describing a particular approach to prepare Global South students for the SDC. The aim was to cover as well different historical trajectories in training for the SDC, and diverse challenges to get engaged in SDC. The authors involved in each experience were asked to reflect on their initiatives, activities, impact, challenges, lessons learned, and how the SDC is embedded in the country's HCI landscape. In addition, they each collected students' perspectives via a questionnaire and short interviews.

Each case study was analyzed and written by the individuals who directly experienced and contributed to the initiative. This approach allowed for a diverse yet authentic representation of the cases, conveying the heterogeneity of each SDC experience.

3 CASE 1: MEXICO AND LEVERAGING THE SDC TO CREATE AND FOSTER AN HCI ECOSYSTEM

In the last 20 years, research and practice in HCI have grown in Mexico. Thus, resulting in the HCI-association AMEXIHC that publishes a local journal and organizes a biannual conference (MEXIHC), and a local chapter of the UXPA. A key aspect motivating this growth has been the effort of academics returning to the country after specializing in HCI abroad. They brought new ideas of how to best promote the field, locally. One of such academics is Mario Moreno Rocha who, after returning to Mexico from his graduate studies in HCI in the University of Glasgow, devoted many efforts into putting HCI on the map, academically and professionally [9, 11]. His work for over 16 years, later together with Carlos Martinez Sandoval, at the Universidad Tecnológica de la Mixteca (Huaquapán de León, Oaxaca, Mexico) has been instrumental to the growth of the field in the country. As part of the efforts, in 2001 they accomplished to integrate an HCI course in their Computer Engineering and Informatics programs curricula and three HCI-modules within their Interactive Systems Master's degree later on.

To continue promoting HCI, the university hired Christian Sturm in 2006. He laid the groundwork for the upcoming success in competitions by initiating the engagement for SDC and by starting the respective training. One of the key-components was assembling multi-disciplinary student teams, composed of members from computer science, design, and economy. The first team reached the semi-finals and came in second place at CHI 2007 SDC. From then on, the university has continuously and successfully participated in the SDC with Mario's and Carlos' training: six teams have made the finals, two teams have come in second place and one team has won the competition.

The students who have participated have grown tremendously by having experienced all the stages of the competition. Further, their experiences participating in the SDC helped to push the field further in the country. For example, Emmanuel Aquino, a former Computer Science student who was part of the team that reached the semi-finals for the first time in 2007, decided to learn more about usability and apply it in his line of work because of the SDC:

The fact of being invited to the competition was already an achievement for us because at the university there was no usability discipline as such and we were competing against universities that already had developed curricula for that discipline. [...] It seems to me that if I hadn't experienced CHI 2007 my perspective would be different, it sparked my interest in usability [...]

Fernando Sernas, another member of that team, expands on the impact that the SDC had on his capacity to further strengthen the use of HCI-related practices in Mexico:

We were notified that our project had been chosen and that we had to go to San Jose California to present it. At first we didn't believe it and neither did the university where we were. [...] During this presentation it was very interesting because we were able to meet literally people from all over the world who were



Figure 1: Interdisciplinary student team from Universidad Tecnológica de la Mixteca at the CHI conference in 2007, 2nd place

working on usability, user-centered design projects. [...] Since we won this contest other very good things happened for me [...], I was able to do my thesis on the usability of web pages and to work on projects that had to do with usability testing. Also, later I was able to get my first job as an interface and experience designer. [...] It was great because everything I learned in this contest that I didn't know before [...] I was applying it little by little until it became part of my job.

Both the internal and external visibility of the students' success helped to secure institutional and industry support to build UsaLab, a state-of-the-art usability lab in a new building dedicated to interactive media [11]. Both national and international visibility in academia and industry led to collaborative opportunities that would not have been possible without the dedication to train the students for the SDC throughout the years. As Nadia Jiménez and Belen Hernández—graduate students who got in second at CHI 2023 SDC—explain, the existence of the lab further helps the sustain the SDC training experience:

The UsaLab provided invaluable guidance: they motivated us to engage in this project, which entailed resolving tangible user issues, facilitating funding to attend, and walked us through how to present to a global audience with clarity and coherence. Coming in second not only affirmed our efforts; it gave our work international visibility.

In sum, the SDC helped to raise funding to increase the area of HCI within the university. This, in turn, supported the continuous preparation of more students for the regional and global SDCs.

4 CASE 2: SOUTH AFRICA AND USING THE SDC TO BUILD HCI AWARENESS IN A GROWING HCI ECOSYSTEM

The presence and impact of HCI in South Africa is indeed growing. The country created its first ACM SIGCHI chapter—CHI-SA—in 2001. At that point, HCI education and research was driven by seven universities in the region. This included the incorporation of the



Figure 2: Participants of the ProteaCHI training and student design competition 2022 in Cape Town

HCI curriculum into the CS/IS and IT undergraduate and postgraduate education. The chapter highlighted that industry awareness, collaboration and the limited number of researchers in the area were obstacles to overcome [12]. The chapter was suspended around 2009. However, the movement that it created, drove the organization of the first African CHI conference in 2016 and the creation of a second South African ACM SIGCHI chapter—ProteaCHI—in 2018. Amongst the chapter's goals are to advance HCI education, research and industry collaborations. The SDCs, both local ones and the CHI competition, provide a promising vehicle to achieve this goal.

The first South African SDC event took place from the 5th to 9th of September 2022 (four days of training, with the final project pitches on the fifth day) at the University of Cape Town, South Africa. The ProteaCHI chairs organized the event with Christian Sturm after he contacted them at the start of the year. The success of the event required that the organizers put in a lot of additional volunteering hours. For example, ProteaCHI advertised the event to the local chapter members, collaborators and peers who in turn informed their students. This was critical to secure participants: a number of students who participated in the competition highlighted that without their teachers efforts to inform them about the event, they would have not applied. Further, the event required the participation of a jury of professionals from academia and the industry who were to later mentor students' CHI 2023 SDC submissions. Also, to make the SDC possible, funding was obtained from the ACM SIGCHI development fund and Varsity college - a private South African university. A total of 6 teams from 4 universities worked on their projects during the local SDC.

The event had an important impact on participants, who were CS or IT students. The SDC's main theme addressing the U.N. Sustainable Development Goals drove many to grapple with social problems such as issues related to educational contexts. Further, for some the workshop was key to help them develop "a different design approach to technological solutions, which in turn could be valuable both professionally and academically". After the workshop, two out of the six participating teams decided to take their projects to the CHI 2023 held in Hamburg, Germany. One of these teams was selected as semi-finalist.

While the local SDC's outcome was highly positive, some barriers stood in the way of increasing the number of students submitting to CHI. First, students indicated that they needed a more frequent follow-up from their assigned mentors, many of whom were hard

to reach after the local competition took place. Another particular factor hindering students' willingness to submit to CHI was the misaligned academic calendars. The South African academic calendar runs from February to November/December and Northern American and European Academic calendar—which is the one CHI often operates under—runs from August/September to May/June. Submission for the CHI 2023 SDC submission took place in mid-January and the event took place at CHI at the end of April or beginning of May. South African students would therefore need to start their project in February and not September when the SDC was held in South Africa. Thus, for many students, work for the CHI competition demanded them to work during their Summer vacation. A further obstacle was that many of the participants were in their final year of their undergraduate degree and thus prioritized being employed in industry shortly after they complete their studies over the completion and submission of their projects to the CHI SDC. For next editions of this local SDC initiative, thus, the timeline for training needs to be reconsidered.

5 CASE 3: ECUADOR AND USING THE SDC TO BUILD HCI AWARENESS IN A NON-EXISTENT HCI ECOSYSTEM

Even though Ecuadorian universities offers various computer science-related undergraduate and graduate programs, there are no HCI-related programs nor UX bootcamps or certifications yet and few universities include HCI as part of the CS curricula. There is also no working SIGCHI Chapter nor a well-organized HCI community yet. In this context, in 2022, Marisol Wong-Villacres—a professor in the Escuela Superior Politécnica del Litoral (ESPOL) in Guayaquil who had recently finished her PhD in Human-Centered Computing in the United States—coordinated a one-semester SDC training experience together with Christian Sturm to motivate her 26 HCI students to submit to the CHI 2023 SDC. The goal was to plant a first seed for fostering HCI research and education in the country. Students worked at different community-based projects (e.g., working with a pet rescuing organization to motivate pet adoption and biking communities to promote safe biking routes) while receiving Marisol's continuous guidance, Christian's monthly online mentoring, and occasional feedback from professionals in Ecuador and abroad. The experience ended with Christian's visit (funded by ACM SIGCHI) to further motivate students to submit their work to the CHI 2023 SDC. Through this approach, Marisol and Christian aimed at giving the entire HCI class a richer educational experience while securing that at least one team would feel motivated to submit. One, 2-member team (Meiyin Chang and Gabriel Cañarte) did submit, thereby becoming the first Ecuadorian team ever submitting to the CHI SDC. Against all expectations, they ended up winning the competition.

Meiyin's and Gabriel's account confirms that the experience of attending CHI and defending their projects to a wider audience is indeed quite enriching for students' ability to critically think about technology design. Gabriel felt that now he knows how “to express myself more, in a more professional way” and Meiyin has noticed how now she is able to analyze arguments more critically: “I can now more easily see what information is needed to support an argument and how an argument can be improved”. Further,

participating in a design competition helped students to have a richer connection with HCI in research and practice. Gabriel, for example, is now considering research as a profession and Meiyin is considering to take more HCI-related courses. This confirms the SDC's potential to help develop HCI as a stronger field in the country.

Continuing the active participation of Ecuadorian students in CHI's SDC, however, is not guaranteed due to numerous difficulties hindering first students' willingness to submit their work to the competition, and then their ability to actually attend the conference. Gabriel's comments highlight how the CHI SDC's requirement to submit all materials in English deters participation: “They (CHI SDC organizers) ask for everything to be in English, the video, the slides, the presentation. We saw how other students decided against submitting because of that”. Meiyin also shared how a lack of clarity on the direct benefits that participation would entail for students deterred participation as well; HCI as a whole is too different from Computer Science and, thus, devoting too much effort to improving HCI skills does not seem as important: “it requires too much research, recruitment efforts and talking to people. All my classmates really want is just coding, they think that is what matters the most”. As Marisol explains, promising those students who dare to overcome these initial obstacles that they would indeed receive the direct benefits of attending the conference was not easy; financial challenges stand in the way: “Christian and I thought of asking SIGCHI for support, however, once we actually applied we learned there were too many limitations: SIGCHI Development Funds are hard to get for public universities, and scholarships like the Gary Marsden Award can only support one student, not entire teams”.



Figure 3: Marisol with Meiyin and Gabriel, the winning team from the SDC at CHI 2023 from Ecuador

The barriers that Meiyin, Gabriel, and Marisol discussed strongly emphasize that submitting to competitions and even participating in them actively does not ensure a direct growth in local HCI educational capacity in the context of a country such as Ecuador, where HCI is not a well-developed field. To help HCI grow as a field, academics and practitioners interested need to clearly carve the pathway for students and professors, making it clear how the competition and HCI knowledge & practice can benefit them, locally. For Gabriel, an important next step to push HCI further is to work with the university so that “it stops treating design competitions as this little thing that only a few selected people can learn about”. Meiyin suggests “to create more spaces where we can work,

interact, talk with other people outside of our context who also care about HCI so that we can help each other and make more friends along the way”. Another aspect that both students highlighted as essential to keep motivating others is securing a mentor who can help through the submission process: “without Marisol we would have not been able to submit, she guided us on what to add to the report, what to do more research on, and so on”. (Meiyin).

6 CASE 4: THE IX IBEROAMERICAN HCI CONFERENCE (JIHCI) AND USING LOCAL EVENTS TO INCREASE REGIONAL PARTICIPATION IN THE CHI SDC

The Ibero-American HCI conference is an annual event that the HCI-Collab Network—a group gathering HCI researchers from France, Spain, Portugal, and Latin America—organizes since 2015. The conference aims at providing a safe, easier-to-access environment for local HCI knowledge production by carrying the event in locations closer to researchers and practitioners, with affordable prices, and in their own languages. During his visit to Ecuador in 2022, which entailed also a workshop for Colombian, Peruvian, and Ecuadorian HCI scholars, Christian Sturm met with Cesar Collazos, the HCI-Collab Network coordinator, and proposed him to organize an SDC during the IX Ibero-American HCI conference taking place in September 2023 in Buenos Aires, Argentina. This SDC’s goal was to motivate and prepare Ibero-American students for later submitting to CHI 2024.

This SDC’s requirements were highly based on the insights gained during the previous Ecuadorian experience so as to maximize participation: students only had to submit a one-pager in English, Spanish, or Portuguese summarizing their project and were offered meals, lodging and local transportation arrangements thanks to the ACM SIGCHI Development Funds. Twenty one students (7 teams) from Mexico, Brasil, Colombia, Ecuador and Argentina applied and were accepted. The Ecuadorian participants, Viviana Muñoz and Yanaleen Pluas, had been part of the Ecuadorian initiative and this time they decided to submit the work they had not send to CHI 2023.

To maximize opportunities for attending students to later submit their work to the CHI SDC, the conference first offered students a four-day workshop on user-centered design and entrepreneurial thinking mentored by Christian Sturm. On the fifth day, a jury with representatives from both academia and industry judged the final presentations and selected the winning team (from the Universidad del Cauca en Popayán, Colombia) as well as a runner-up (from Universidade Presbiteriana Mackenzie in São Paulo, Brasil).

Participants shared how being part of this SDC furthered their appreciation and knowledge of HCI and beyond. Juan Hurtado, member of the winning team, explained this further: “I learned a lot, not only about HCI knowledge, but also about how to present a proposal to a jury to convince them of the work being done. Being able to manage to abstract an idea and be concise in the presentation is something I managed to learn from the event. It was an unforgettable experience”. For Viviana and Yanaleen participating in this SDC became a determining factor for now considering to submit their work to the CHI 2024 SDC. As Yanaleen explained “I know understand better why these competitions are important and

I really feel motivated to improve our submission and take it to the CHI 2024 SDC”. Viviana felt a similar motivation: “I really want take this [her project] beyond the classroom and explore how it can work in the real world”.

Amongst the SDC’s aspects that participating students remarked as critical to keep them motivated and interested on the competition were 1) the simple and straightforward nature of the required materials and 2) the feasibility to interact with so many peers from their region in their own language. As Juan Hurtado, shared, the social factor (which the CHI SDC does not really foster) was critical: “I met a group of people who have helped me a lot and with whom I hope to keep in touch and have a friendship with them”. Viviana’s comment highlights how the social factor also impacted her critical view of HCI: “By talking about all our different projects with my peers from other parts of Latin America, I was able to see technology design with a different set of eyes; it is not only something that you do for a bit and then you move on, it is a commitment to appreciate the communities behind existing issues and to constantly understand in more depth their problems and motivations”. The enthusiasm that the collaboration amongst students managed to foster also drove students to create a student chapter within the HCI-Collab Network, which is expected to encourage the participation of more students in the various activities that are organized, and in particular to continue participating in the SDC at the Ibero-American level.

The accounts of Juan, Viviana, and Yanaleen strongly suggest that this SDC did advance its goal. Organizers expect to improve the experience in upcoming years by integrating teams from different regions and ethnicities (e.g., indigenous communities). However, moving forward, it is critical to reflect on potential limitations. As Cesar, the conference organizer, shared, securing financial support is critical to keep this effort alive: “Being able to count on this financial support has allowed students from different countries to participate and generate space for cooperation.” Although this financial support—which covered meals and lodging—was critical, it is also important to consider that in many cases it might not be enough. Yanaleen and Viviana, for example, almost did not attend the event for they had no way to pay for the flight tickets on their own. Their university could not support them because it only help student if they publish articles in indexed databases such as Scopus, which was not the SDC’s case. In the end, they had to borrow money from their parents. To ensure the future of regional SDCs, thus, it is critical to secure mechanisms for making these events self-sustainable.

In upcoming SDCs it is also pertinent to unpack HCI’s role in students’ professional lives. As Viviana explained, even after participating in the competition and developing a genuine interest in HCI, she still struggles to see how learning about HCI can help her, professionally: “I do not see it as competitive field for me to pursue a specialization for working here in Ecuador at least, I don’t really see how I could make a living out of it”.

7 DISCUSSION

The case studies presented in this paper shed light on the SDC from different local perspectives and temporal experiences. All countries who partook in the study highlighted that HCI creditability as a



Figure 4: Student teams that participated in the SDC and prior four-day training sessions at IX Iberoamerican HCI conference in Buenos Aires, Argentina

discipline is largely disputed. Consequently, the introduction of HCI into the curriculum of study programs is still in its infancy in most of the locations. In addition, organizations outside of academia rarely acknowledge the added value that HCI as a field can bring to the table. Therefore, the possibilities to start a career in HCI or user experience after graduation is still rather limited.

The Universidad Tecnológica de la Mixteca in Mexico has more than 16 years' experience of preparing and training student teams for the competition. This has resulted in a robust internal organisational support for logistics and finances, which has grown further with the university's students competing worldwide against better-known institutions at the CHI conference. This is only possible with a high level of personal commitment, passion and tremendous effort of the students' mentors and supervisors.

The same is true for the case of ESPOL in Ecuador. Without the high level of personal commitment, this success of winning the CHI SDC in 2023 would not have been possible. Many obstacles and doubts, however, stand in the way for raising the awareness and building a local self-sustainable HCI eco-system. For each event, mobility costs, logistical challenges of transferring money between countries and the lack of acknowledgement regarding the added value of the activities around the SDC result in tremendous efforts to get the project started.

The importance of HCI in South Africa within universities, as in other Global South countries, has regrettably been downplayed. Gratefully, this situation is changing with industries increasing their demand for User Experience staff, resulting in a resurgence of interest in the universities. The SDC provides a vehicle to help operationalize both theoretical and practical elements of the HCI field, and to bring industry and academia together. However, there is a struggle to acquire funding to run these training programs with limited governmental support.

More local events such as the SDC at ProteaCHI, the JIHCI, or AfriCHI 2023 are therefore needed. Accepted student teams participate in a multiple-day training workshop to develop their ideas further onsite prior to the final pitches. This type of event, where students compete with each other instead of against each other, promotes not only the dissemination of HCI-related knowledge but strengthens community building.

The collaboration between different student teams and the inclusion of student teams anywhere in the world is possible with a

common design brief. This is given with the Sustainable Development Goals of the United Nations and should be continued. Regional events embedded in conferences as seen in South Africa and Argentina help to create a flow of interest. They should be part of an overall SIGCHI strategy to increase to outreach and maturity for HCI in the Global South. Institutions such as the ACM or SIGCHI could play a vital role in creating the supporting infrastructure in terms of financial and logistical support. We need to rethink the structure of funding options such as the Gary Marsden Travel Award and the SIGCHI development fund. Thus, the reimbursement model is a huge obstacle for a lot of students in the Global South given that they simply don't have the financial means to pay for transportation or accommodations upfront. Hybrid models only solve a small part of this challenge given that the level of community building seen at JIHCI and ProteaCHI are simply not possible online. Mutual online presence and participation in the classroom by mentors, researchers and lecturers around the world and the integration of the SDC into the curriculum, as seen in the case of Ecuador, are a first step. Nevertheless, real community-building across borders needs personal encounters.

In sum, it has been shown that the SDC can be a great venue to raise awareness for HCI in the Global South. It inspires students to seek further insights into the field of HCI, builds communities, bridges cultural barriers, gets academia and industry connected, strengthen the position of HCI within universities of the Global South, and increases regional and global visibility.

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